

BRP: DAY ONE — LONDON FALLS

Event 159 · Basic Role-Playing (BRP) · South Bank, London · Sunday 17 May 2026, 10:47 AM · 5–6 players · 3.5 hrs

"The zombies are the weather. The people are the story."

GM TRUTH — DO NOT SHARE

Thursday 14 May: biosafety Level 3 breach at Meridian Biosciences (sub-basement lab, Elephant & Castle) released MX-9 — a Ministry of Defence-contracted neurological disruption agent that induces autonomic cascade failure mimicking brain death, followed within hours by reanimation of motor function without higher cognition. By Saturday evening two lab workers had reanimated inside the sealed facility. By 7:14 AM Sunday a third reached the public drainage network. Metropolitan Police officers responding to 'confused and aggressive persons' had no PPE. Two were bitten. COBR convened at 9:00 AM. The NHS Emergency Alert was not issued until 10:47 AM — a 2-hour delay based on a containment-first assessment that was wrong, or at least too slow. The military cordon being established 'north of the river' is NOT a rescue cordon. It is a containment cordon. The working assumption inside COBR: South London below the Thames cannot be held. The cordon is along the north bank. The government is not coming south of the river. They are closing the door.

■ INTRODUCTION — NHS ALERT FIRES (~15 min)

Locations: South Bank — scattered 600m between Waterloo Station and Borough Market

Introduce each character in 30 seconds before the alert fires. Give each player their opening moment: Kira waiting on a friend; Dev pretending to work; Maggie on her Sunday Jubilee Walkway; Olu clocking into the Shard; Priya at the Southwark Centre; Tom in his van on Waterloo Road. Every phone buzzes simultaneously. Red screen. Two-tone alarm — the one everyone has heard in tests but never for real. Text: EMERGENCY ALERT — UK Government — STAY INDOORS. AVOID ALL CONTACT WITH PERSONS WHO APPEAR CONFUSED OR AGGRESSIVE. THIS IS NOT A TEST. Let it sit. Then: across the street, someone screams. It doesn't sound like shock. It sounds like pain. Players converge on a bus crash on Southwark Street — the driver had a medical episode, is dead at the wheel, no external wound.

Clues / handouts: 159-H00-B (South Bank map, A5) · 159-H00-C (NHS Emergency Alert screengrab — display on device or print phone-sized)

■ ACT ONE — SOMETHING IS WRONG (~60 min)

Locations: Bus Crash (Southwark St/Southwark Bridge Rd) · Borough Market · Jubilee Walkway · The Shard Lobby

Among the crash crowd: a man in a high-vis vest standing very still, head tilted exactly 15 degrees. Eyes open and tracking but not focusing. Passive until touched or approached within arm's reach — then immediate violence. Bite: 1D4 + Infection (CON roll or symptoms in hours). Head shot only for instant kill (~20% or Special Success). Body damage reduces Move but not aggression. Callum Fraser (uniformed PC, no PPE, looking for someone to tell him what to do) has a radio fragment: 'First reports... Elephant... 07:14' — the government knew nearly two hours before the alert. He hasn't shared it yet. [Essential Clue 2] Fatima Osei is locking up her Borough Market stall with complete economy of motion — not panicking, assessing. She has the van keys (driver missing), knows every exit, has seen the 2011 disorder and a gas explosion. This is different, and she will say so. The Jubilee Walkway: Maggie's Sunday route takes her past two early infected — one collapsed, one standing waist-deep in the Thames facing the far bank. Not drowning. Not doing anything. SAN 1/1D6. Borough Market breaks at the 1:00 trigger — infected bites a vendor in full view; stampede begins; group is pushed south. If players stall: a second infected stumbles into the market, already fully turned, moving toward the most densely populated stall area.

Clues / handouts: High-vis man onset [E1] · Callum radio fragment — 'Elephant... 07:14' [E2] · Social media posts (H1-A) [Optional]

Pacing: Market breaking is the hard Act 2 trigger. Fast-track at 1:00: fully-turned infected bites vendor in full view. Stampede. Push south immediately.

■ ACT TWO — THE LONG WALK SOUTH (~90 min)

Locations: Bermondsey Street · Blue Anchor Pub · Bermondsey Street Pharmacy · Guy's Hospital Car Park

Bermondsey Street: narrow, residential, quieter than the market — the false calm will unsettle. Several shops can be raided for supplies. Blue Anchor Pub: 12 survivors barricaded inside — food, phone chargers, first aid kit. DANNY (30s, quiet, sitting in corner with jacket pulled over his arm) was bitten 40 minutes ago and has told no one. He is deteriorating visibly. Dr Sharif identifies him within 5 minutes if given the chance to assess the group. Medicine/First Aid (Kira or Sharif): recognises neurological cascade, not shock. If players stay 30+ minutes: Danny reanimates inside. SAN 1D2/1D8. Pharmacy: DECLAN and RYAN looting the drug safe. Craft knife and bicycle lock. Persuade/Fast Talk to talk them down. Spot Hidden: Ryan is injured — blood on his sleeve is from a bite, not the looting. Marcus (19, livestreamer, 41k viewers, 31% battery, riding a Lime bike): real-time information from his live chat. Drone footage of the city. A walking liability in any stealth situation. HELEN (late 60s, visitor, tote bag) keeps saying it's a gas leak. Psychology or direct conversation: she has a Cabinet Office background and knows a 'protocol' exists. She has seen the name Meridian Biosciences on a briefing. Save her extraordinary moment — stepping in front of an infected to buy someone else time — for when the table least expects it. REANIMATION (required story beat): an NPC the players know turns. Helen is recommended. Separate her briefly — she stays behind to help someone, or goes back for something. The group turns to find her twenty metres back, standing very still, head tilting. Give it four full seconds before she moves. Callum's radio (after reanimation): 'cordon... north bank... all units hold position.' Give Callum a moment before players respond. He has been trying to do his job all day. He trusted the institution. He does not say anything for a beat.

Clues / handouts: Callum's cordon fragment [E3] · Danny's bite [Optional] · Ryan's bite [Optional] · Helen's Cabinet Office background [Optional]

Pacing: Reanimation must happen by the 2:30 mark. The choice of victim is yours — Helen has the most emotional impact.

■ ACT THREE — THE BRIDGE OR THE RIVER (~30 min)

Locations: Tooley Street → Tower Bridge OR Bermondsey → Blackfriars Underpass → Bankside Pier (RIB)

30 minutes of viable light left. Two routes: Tower Bridge: broad, exposed, infected clustering at the approach. Armed civilian BRIDGE GROUP controls the north gatehouse. Leader PETE (50s, foreman, fire axe at his leg, completely calm): he will interrogate the group and will not let infected through. Psychology: he has already turned away two infected people and dealt with the consequences. He is not cruel. He is broken. He is not wrong. Arguing with Pete should feel like arguing with a mirror. Bankside Pier: 6m RIB normally used for tourist runs. Path requires the Blackfriars underpass — dark since noon, 12+ infected inside. SAN 1D4/1D8 in the underpass. RIB engine starts on the third try — noise draws infected if loud. Fuel gauge unread: players must check. THE COST (required by 3:05, before bridge or boat is reached): Option A — NPC accident (Helen, Fatima, Callum, or Marcus — the one who has become most significant to the group). Not a sacrifice — bad luck, random cruelty. Option B — A player character at low HP; offer a final moment, something given to the group. Option C — Pete refuses someone (correctly identifies symptoms); group must choose to leave that person or risk the bridge. No third option provided.

Clues / handouts: Pete's radio confirms cordon [11] · RIB fuel gauge [12 — practical jeopardy]

Pacing: At 3:05 the cost happens regardless. At 3:10 the bridge or boat is reached. Hard deadline: transition to epilogue.

■ EPILOGUE — WHAT IT COST (~15 min)

Locations: North bank or on the river

Full Survival: all PCs through. London burns behind them. They do not know where they're going. They have each other, for now. Partial Survival: survivors turn to look at the gap. Someone is missing. The group that remains is changed by who isn't in it. Pyrrhic: everyone who didn't start the day with a player is dead. The PCs are alive. They are alone. The true story — Meridian Biosciences, MX-9, COBR's two-hour delay — is available for a second session. Do not volunteer it. Helen and Priya between them can get close, but the full picture is deliberately withheld. Let the players pull on the thread.

Pacing: Minimum 15 minutes. Do not rush to debrief. Close each character's personal hook.

KEY NPCS

Fatima Osei Borough Market stall owner, 50s — *de facto* NPC leader

STR 13 CON 14 INT 17 POW 15 · HP 13 · Persuade 75%, Spot Hidden 70%, Drive 60%

Not panicking — assessing. Knows every market exit. Has the supply van keys. The most competent non-player in the scenario.

Callum Fraser Metropolitan Police constable, 28, Scottish

STR 13 CON 12 INT 13 POW 12 · HP 13 · Persuade 55%, Spot Hidden 60%, Baton 55%

Looking for someone to tell him what to do. Key radio fragment: 07:14 reports from Elephant & Castle. Devastated by the cordon.

Dr Yasmin Sharif NHS Emergency Medicine Consultant, off-duty

CON 13 INT 18 POW 15 · HP 12 · Medicine 85%, First Aid 90%, Psychology 70%

Calm, unhurried efficiency. Will name what this is. Wants to reach St Thomas' — wrong. May need to be talked out of it.

Marcus Livestreamer, 19, Black British

DEX 14 INT 14 · HP 11 · 41,000 live viewers, selfie stick, 31% battery

Liability in stealth. Real-time information source. Terrified beneath practised content-creator energy.

Helen Late 60s visitor — *says it's a gas leak*

Cabinet Office background. Knows the name Meridian Biosciences from a briefing.

Save her extraordinary moment for when the table least expects it. Best candidate for the reanimation beat.

Pete Bridge Group leader, 50s, former foreman

STR 14 CON 13 INT 14 · HP 14 · Persuade 60%, Spot Hidden 65% · Fire axe (1D8+1D4)

Not wrong. Not cruel. Broken. Knows the north bank cordon is real — hasn't told the people with him. Don't make him a villain.

PLAYER CHARACTERS

Kira South Bank café — *waiting for a friend* · medical background

Personal hook: three NHS group chat messages she hasn't opened.

Dev Krishnamurthy Borough Market café — *freelance software engineer*

Hook: flatmate's voice note about spare keys. He hasn't replied. Not relevant to anything. Normal Sunday.

Maggie Donnelly Jubilee Walkway — *retired Metropolitan Police, 22 years*

Knows the South Bank better than most people know their own sitting rooms. The figure in the river is on her route.

Olu Adeyemi Shard lobby security guard — *Sunday overtime*

Building radio. CCTV access. High vantage — three plumes of smoke all south of expected. Keys to staff-only areas.

Priya Mehta Science journalist — *Southwark Centre weekend exhibition*

Editor's message she filed away: 'Something came in. Might be relevant.' Closest to the Meridian truth.

Tom Becker Scaffolding worker — *van on Waterloo Road, radio on*

Called his mum this morning. She didn't answer. He left a voicemail that was mostly road noise.

HANDOUTS

159-H00-B — South Bank area map — Waterloo to Borough, key locations marked (A5, ink-sketch style, give before play)

159-H00-C — NHS Emergency Alert screengrab — red screen, government text (display on GM device or print phone-sized)

159-H01-A — Five social media posts in screenshot format — contradictory; 'it's a gas leak' / 'something bit a man' / 'all Jubilee services suspended'

159-H01-B — Callum's radio fragment — partial transcript on police notepad page; 'first reports... Elephant... 07:14'

159-H03-A — Tower Bridge approach sketch — evening light, figures at gatehouse, Pete visible with axe at leg

159-H03-B — Bankside Pier sketch — RIB in foreground, Blackfriars underpass dark mouth behind, water reflecting fire

SAN TABLE: Standing figure in river (not drowning) 1/1D6 · First infected seen (high-vis man) 1/1D6 · Danny reanimates in pub 1D2/1D8 · Reanimation of known NPC 1D3/1D8 · Blackfriars underpass (density + darkness + moaning) 1D4/1D8